



WINNING THAT GOVERNMENT CONTRACTING AWARD · SESSION 1 OF 4

Business Development Lifecycle

Brandon Mason · Maryland Small Business Development Center
Monday, September 28, 2026



Scan now: your worksheet

BEFORE WE START

Scan your worksheet

- 1** **Point your phone camera at the code.** Or click the link in the Zoom chat.
- 2** **Fill in page 1 now.** Name, email, business, where you are today.
- 3** **Keep the tab open.** We come back to it three times today.

Link is in the Zoom chat

When you submit at the end, the capture template and every link from today land in your inbox.



TODAY

What we're covering

01 Where to find government opportunities

03 Revenue strategies: where you fit right now

05 The six phases of business development

02 How the government actually buys

04 The 36-month capture pipeline

06 Go/No-Go: knowing when to walk away

PART 1

Finding opportunities

Where to look

Federal	SAM.gov · the single federal marketplace	\$\$\$
State	eMaryland Marketplace Advantage (eMMA)	\$30k+
County & City	Howard, Montgomery, Prince George's, Baltimore Co., Baltimore City, Annapolis	\$15k+

Also look at: subcontractor & expiring-contract lists · master contract award lists · procurement forecasts · networking, industry days, social media

How the government actually buys

HOW THEY BUY

Federal	Existing contract vehicles (IDIQs, GSA Schedule, SeaPort-e, OASIS+, OTAs), open solicitations on SAM.gov, DSBS for set-asides, forecasts
State	eMMA for \$30k+
County / City	Procurement portals for \$15k+

BELOW ~\$15K

Purchase cards.

A government credit card. No formal solicitation required. If you sell something an agency needs for under ~\$15k, a contracting officer can just buy it.

QUICK COMPARISON

Government vs. B2B

	Government	B2B
Where	Portals & contract vehicles	Supplier portals, direct outreach
Process	Formal: RFPs, RFQs, set-asides	RFPs, RFQs, traditional sales
Timeline	Months to years	Weeks to months
Rules	Compliance on top of everything	Fewer rules
Relationships	Matter, within the rules	Often drive the deal

The capture discipline works for both. Government adds compliance on top.

PART 2

Revenue strategies: where do you fit?

Three revenue strategies

STRATEGY 1

Sub under small

Start here. Find a small-business prime with the contract, past performance and certifications, and offer your skills as a sub.

STRATEGY 2

Prime with agencies

When you have: federal experience, 3+ years of revenue, clearances if needed, strategic partnerships.

STRATEGY 3 · PARALLEL TRACK

Sub under large

Large primes need small subs to hit small-business goals (often 23%+). Steady, but a smaller piece of a bigger pie.

Know which strategy you're running right now.

Certifications = teaming leverage

Early on, certifications are about **subcontracting**, not priming.

8(a)

MBE

EDWOSB

SDVOSB

HUBZone

- They make you the partner a prime needs
- SDVOSB and some others rarely see large prime awards (mostly VA)
- Maryland MBE matters most on state contracts
- The SBDC helps with certifications, free
- Tedious, not hard

WORKSHEET CHECKPOINT · SECTION A

Where do you fit?

Tap Next to Section A. Which strategy are you running right now, and which one agency or buyer would you focus on first?

Link is in the Zoom chat

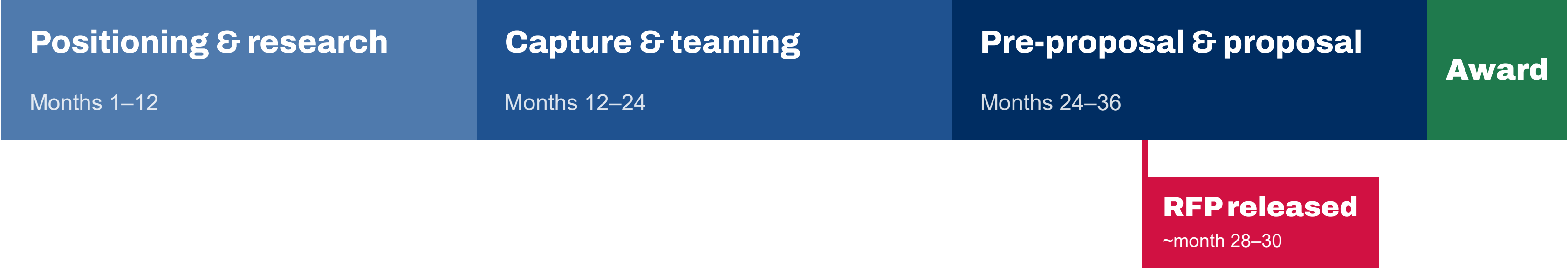


Lost the tab? Scan again.

PART 3

The 36-month capture pipeline

The real timeline: 36 months



You will lose if you wait until the RFP is released.

The first proposal is the hardest

150+

hours to write your first federal proposal



- Processes and templates make every cycle faster
- One agency or customer speeds it up even more
- 3 weeks on a proposal you miss the deadline for = lost opportunity

Your marketing collateral

CAPABILITY STATEMENT · ONE PAGE

Company · contact	
Core competencies	Differentiators
Past performance	NAICS · certs · UEI/CAGE

Have several versions, one per buyer or NAICS. **Pro tip:** image-search “Capability Statement [your NAICS]” for real examples.

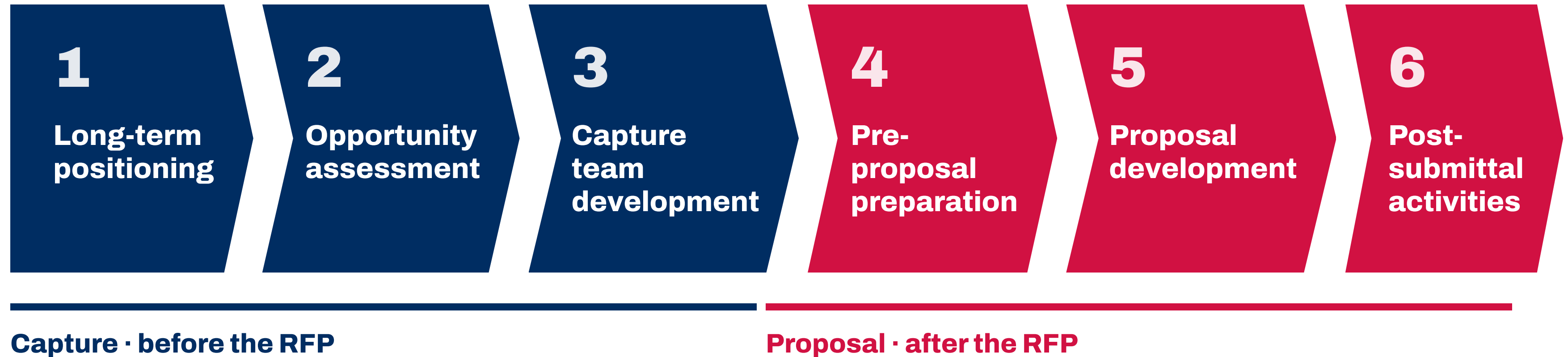
BUYERS WILL GOOGLE YOU

- ✓ No website = you don't exist
- ✓ No social media = you don't exist
- ✓ Neglected social media = red flag
- ✓ It doesn't have to be fancy. It has to exist and look professional.

PART 4

The six phases of business development

The business development lifecycle



Long-term positioning

- ✓ Identify your strategic markets: where do you want to play?
- ✓ Assess market direction and upcoming opportunities
- ✓ Benchmark your capabilities: where are your gaps?
- ✓ Build strategic alliances: teaming partners, mentors, primes
- ✓ Set criteria to prioritize (you can't chase everything)
- ✓ Start marketing: industry days, relationships, get known

Opportunity assessment

- Gather preliminary customer intelligence
- Attend industry briefings and pre-solicitation conferences
- Understand basic requirements; identify probable competitors
- Early analysis: is this a fit? can you compete?
- **Make the Bid/No-Bid decision**
- If Go: assign a capture manager (even if it's you)



Capture team development

Capture manager	owns the strategy and the win
Proposal manager	owns the document and process
Solution architect / SME	owns the technical approach
Pricing strategist	owns the numbers
Business development	owns the relationship

- Establish customer contacts
- Gather and analyze program intelligence
- Write the capture strategy and plan
- Set the bid and proposal budget
- Start teaming and subcontractor relationships
- Define your winning price

In a small business, one person may fill 2 or 3 of these.

Pre-proposal preparation

- Proposal strategy, tasks, budget and schedule
- Work breakdown structure (WBS)
- Teaming and subcontractor statements of work
- Outline from Sections L and M of the RFP
- Reuse what you can from past proposals
- Draft the Executive Summary; hold a kickoff

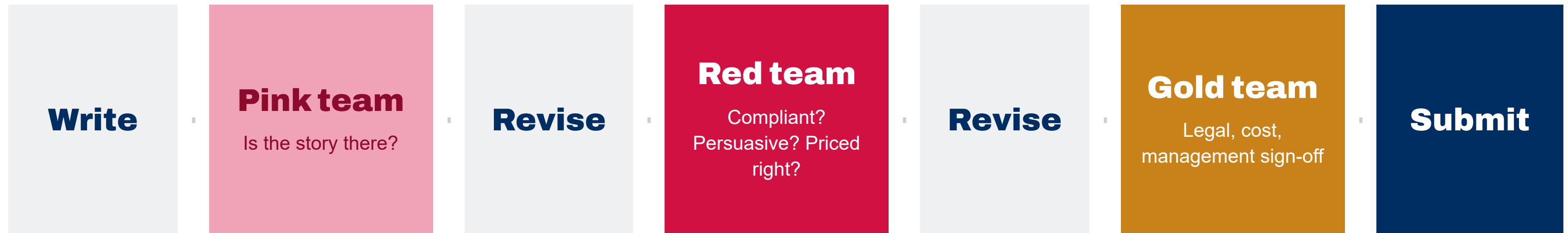
KEY OUTPUTS

Compliance matrix

Storyboards

Map Section L (instructions) and Section M (evaluation) before you write a word. Template in Session 3.

Proposal development



Never submit a proposal that only its writers have read.

Post-submittal activities

- Keep all proposal documentation organized
- Answer clarification requests
- Orals, demos, discussions
- Revalidate pricing if asked
- Negotiate if selected
- Run lessons learned

**Always request a
debrief.**

Win or lose.

PART 5

Go/No-Go: the decision that saves you

Probability of win: the Four C's

Customer

Do you know them? Have you engaged? Do you understand their pain?

Competition

Who else is bidding? Who's the incumbent, and are they happy with them?

Capabilities

Can you do the work? Do you have past performance on this type of contract?

Cost

Can you win on price? Do you understand the pricing structure?

Weak on two or more? Red flag.

WORKSHEET CHECKPOINT · SECTION B

Score one opportunity

Section B: name one opportunity you're watching and rate it 1 to 5 on Customer, Competition, Capabilities and Cost. Then make the call: Go or No-Go.

Link is in the Zoom chat



Lost the tab? Scan again.

Be selective

No-Go if you

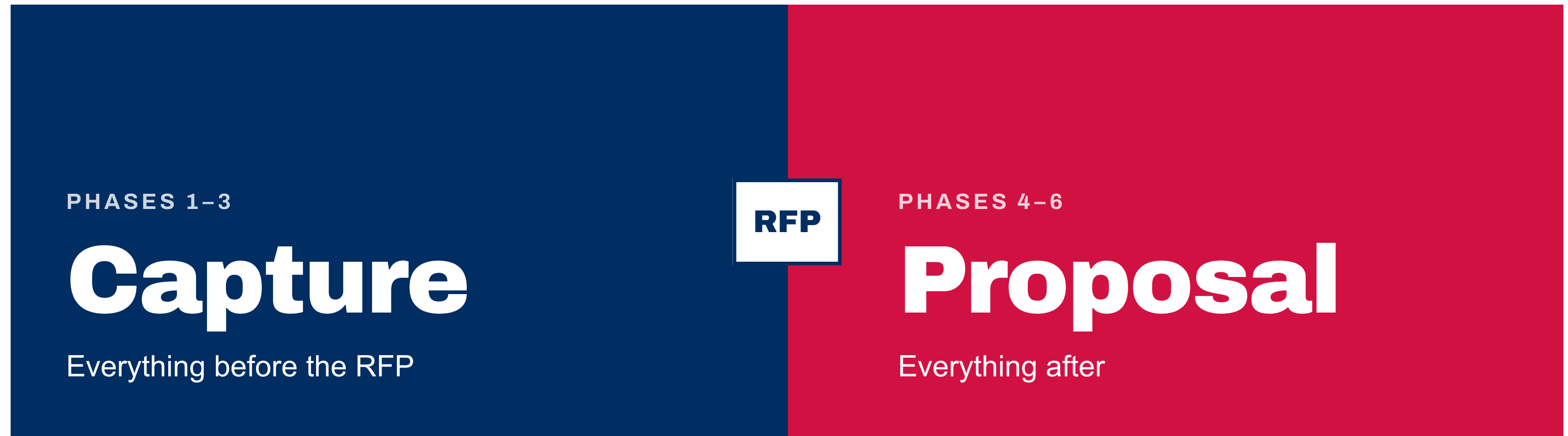
- Lack expertise in the work
- Have a business or ethical conflict
- Would stretch resources too thin
- Don't believe it's real or attainable
- Don't have time for an *excellent* proposal

Go if you

- Have expertise in the work
- Have resources to perform
- Have time for an excellent proposal
- Can submit a letter of intent if required

Weigh probability of win, cost to propose, and estimated profit.

Capture before, proposal after



Most small businesses only do proposal. Consistent winners do both.

TODAY

What to remember

1

Look beyond SAM.gov

State, county and city have lower barriers

2

Know your strategy

Subbing, priming, or both. Be honest.

3

Think in 36 months

Winners start years before the RFP

4

Build templates now

The first proposal is the hardest

5

Be selective

Not every opportunity is yours

6

Always debrief

Win or lose

Submit your worksheet

WEDNESDAY, SEPT 30 · 10:00 A.M. · SESSION 2

Team roles & responsibilities

- Who does what on a proposal team
- Scaling roles when you're one to three people
- Running color team reviews
- When to bring in outside help

WORKSHEET · SECTION C

Write your one step, then submit.

Your inbox gets: this deck with notes, the capture management template, and links to SAM.gov, eMMA, county portals and forecasts.





Questions?

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No-cost, one-on-one consulting. Register as an SBDC client: mdsbdc.ecenterdirect.com/signup



Register for 1:1 advising